present Akbar as the ‘good’ Muslim ruler to oppose Aurangzeb’s ‘bad’ ruler image, and past the even more lamentable excoriating of all Muslim rulers. We must reassess these constructs, deconstruct the various legacies we have inherited from our colonial past and arrive at an objective understanding of our history and key figures who people it. This is especially true of larger-than-life personalities like Akbar.

This book is divided into six parts, each of which is further subdivided into several chapters. Each part is dedicated to a significant phase in Akbar’s life. Part 1 (1526–1561) of the book traces the arrival of the Mughals into India from Central Asia, the establishing of the Mughal Empire by Babur in 1526, and the peregrinations of Humayun, the second Padshah of Hindustan. These are the years in which Humayun lays the foundation of the great Mughal miniature painting tradition, first in Kabul and then in Delhi, and elaborates symbols of kingship that would endure for centuries, while the young Akbar resolutely resists all his father’s efforts to educate him. After Humayun’s sudden death, Akbar becomes Padshah under the able regency first of Bairam Khan and then Maham Anaga. Akbar at this stage remains uninvolved in the running of the empire, satisfied to let affairs of state lie in the capable hands of his regents while he immerses himself in hunting.

In Part 2 (1561–1569), we find Akbar suddenly galvanized into action and finally assuming his role of Padshah Ghazi of Hindustan, first in Delhi and then in Agra. This is a time dominated by the Turki–Chaghatai nobility, with a small but increasing influx of Persian merchants, soldiers, and artists. At this time, Akbar gives enormous impetus to the development of Mughal miniatures by commissioning the *Hamzanama* (*The Adventures of Amir Hamza*), the largest artistic endeavour undertaken by a Padshah. We see here a youthful Akbar slowly discovering the latent, almost untameable power he has within himself, and finding ways to focus his blistering energy. The court continues to evolve, incorporating many new Rajput elements through Akbar’s Rajput wives and their relatives as Rajasthan is folded into the Mughal Empire after two determined and bloody sieges: Chittor and Ranthambore.

In Part 3 (1569–1578), the capital shifts to Fatehpur Sikri where Akbar builds his red sandstone dream city on a hillock inhabited by a Sufi saint. As a fitting testament to Akbar’s unique vision, the different buildings and structures Akbar built in Fatehpur Sikri continue to baffle scholars even